is listed as a ‘Nabob Khandan’, a Muslim zamindar or landowner from the upper ranks of society. The man on the right holding a betel-nut case is described as a ‘tamboolie lubay’ or Muslim betel-nut (areca) seller from the lower ranks. The man in the middle is named as a ‘Tanjore razabut’, a Hindu Rajput of the Kshatriya caste. From a volume of thirty watercolours of castes and occupations from the Tanjore region, c. 1830.

Isolated acts of violence now began to occur, nearly always involving a group of Mappila cultivators turning on a Jenmi landlord and killing him. These outbreaks became increasingly serious, leading the British authorities in 1852 to deport Sayyid Fazal Pookoya Thangal to the Yemen. The British administrator who had ordered his exile, Henry Conolly, Collector and Magistrate of Calicut, was then murdered in his bungalow by the Sayyid’s followers. Further outrages followed, all ruthlessly put down by the authorities. Disturbances in 1896 in Chembrasseri and Mancheri ended with the shooting dead of ninety-two Mappila rioters.

A generation later another Thangal, Sayyid Sanulla Makti Thangal of Malappuram, assumed leadership of the radicals, initially to counter what he saw as the growing influence of the Christian missionaries among the Mappila community. However, he became increasingly troubled by the failure of local Muslims to recognise the advantages of modern education. To this end, he devoted much of his life to spreading the message of education, while also taking on both the Christian missionaries and those among his own people who were urging Muslims to turn their backs on all things unIslamic. The Sayyid was also far ahead of his time in recognising that women in the Muslim community could equally be empowered through education, citing the example of the Prophet’s young wife Ayesha. His name is frequently cited as a supporter of the Mappilas’ armed struggle against the British but all the known evidence suggests the opposite: that while remaining a fierce critic of British rule, Sanulla Makti Thangal nevertheless opposed armed struggle against the ruling power, with a particular